Silent Evasion: Measuring the Adversarial Fragility of Small Language Models Used for Security Triage

Muhammad Daud Khan
Qurtuba University of Science & Information Technology
Dera Ismail Khan, Pakistan
daudkhan@qurtuba.edu.pk

ABSTRACT

Security teams often use small AI text classifiers to sort incoming emails and text messages. The classifier decides whether a message is *malicious* (harmful) or *benign* (safe) before a human reviews it. In this paper, we test what happens when an attacker makes small text edits, called perturbations, to fool the classifier. We show that evasion rates can only be measured fairly under a *conditional* test rule: researchers must only attack messages that the model originally caught, re-check every original message during testing, and limit the attacker to a realistic edit budget per sample.

We test this method on three open, lightweight language models (1.7 billion to 3.8 billion parameters) without extra training (zero-shot) on phishing emails and SMS spam (known as smishing). We test 2,079 caught messages using 8,047 model queries under a 15% total edit budget. At first glance, the models look quite resistant to simple edits. Small character changes (like typos or look-alike letters) flip only 0.0–5.0% of caught messages. Simple word swaps flip only 1.0–5.1% while changing only 6.2–9.2% of words, about half the share of units the character attack spends.

However, a more targeted search changes the picture. When we rank word replacements by their actual impact on the model's decision (a saliency-guided word attack), the success rate rises to 4.6%, compared to 2.7% for random word swaps. This guided attack achieves 46 flips across 1,001 attempts, averaging 23 model queries per message. In paired comparisons on the same messages, the guided attack flips 33 messages that random edits miss, while random edits flip only 7 that guided edits miss (exact McNemar test $p = 4\times10^{-5}$). A similar but smaller gap appears between word and character edits (26 versus 10, $p = 0.011$). This shows that vulnerability is concentrated in a few key words rather than spread evenly across the vocabulary. Evasion rates depend heavily on the quality of the attacker's search strategy.

Two other key findings help interpret these numbers. First, text edits do not transfer well across different models. When we test saved edits against other models, only 0.9% of caught messages flip off the diagonal. Second, continuous probability scores (the model's internal confidence) do not always match the final text decision. The two channels agree on 941 of 1,001 rows, matching perfectly for one model and diverging on the other two. We report final text decisions throughout and treat this gap as an important measurement finding. For defences, cleaning look-alike characters stops all character-level evasions and barely dents the guided attack (7.5% to 6.9%). Adjusting decision cutoffs (re-thresholding) to maintain a 5% false-alarm budget can actually increase evasions for models with uncalibrated probability scores.

Our main practical takeaway is that under small edit budgets, neither overall accuracy nor the distance from the decision threshold orders how often a model flips: the model with the most flips is not the least accurate, and its probability channel saturates, so no margin can be read on it. Robustness therefore has to be measured per model rather than inferred from accuracy or confidence. Furthermore, attack success rates must always be reported with their exact sample count (denominator), a statistical confidence interval, and the specific search method used. A result of 0 out of 188 is an upper limit of 2.0%, not proof of absolute security. We release all frozen datasets, attack code, and individual sample records to support reproducible security evaluations.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Security and privacy** → **Intrusion/anomaly detection and malware mitigation**; • **Computing methodologies** → *Natural language processing*.

KEYWORDS

adversarial text, small language models, phishing detection, smishing, security triage, evaluation methodology

1 INTRODUCTION

A phishing email that reaches a security analyst has usually passed several initial spam filters. Often, the next security layer is a small language model (an AI text classifier). The model makes a fast, automated decision: is this message malicious (harmful) or benign (safe)? Small open models with 1 to 4 billion parameters are popular for this job. They run on a single standard GPU, can be hosted privately inside an organization, and require no special training examples [7, 13]. However, an attacker can change their message to bypass this filter.

This paper tests how much small text edits (called perturbations) help an attacker evade detection. We limit the attacker to simple changes that a human reader would easily overlook. These changes include look-alike characters (such as replacing Latin letters with similar Cyrillic letters), tiny typos, and simple synonyms. All edits together stay under a strict 15% edit budget per message. We measure how often these edits cause the model's decision (verdict) to flip from *malicious* to *benign*.

Why the denominator is crucial. An attack success rate (ASR) is meaningless without knowing its denominator (the total number of tested samples). In security research, two different denominators are often used. The first counts all malicious messages. The second counts only the messages that the clean model correctly identified as malicious before the attack. The second definition is

what truly matters for evasion: if a model never caught a message in the first place, modifying that message cannot count as a successful attack flip [10]. Therefore, we only attack messages that the clean model originally flagged as malicious. We re-test every original message during the attack process to confirm this label, and we report the baseline catch rate alongside every ASR.

Contributions.

(1) **A strict, reproducible evasion evaluation protocol** (Section 3): We use a conditional denominator with re-verified original messages, an exact Levenshtein edit distance budget shared across all edits, identical prompts between baseline and attack phases, and public sample records so every result can be verified.
(2) **An empirical evaluation of three small open models** (Section 5): Testing 2,079 caught messages across 8,047 model queries gave 40 decision flips under the two random attacks; the guided attack has its own totals in Section 6. We test character-level and word-level edits under the same budget, provide 95% confidence intervals for every row, and evaluate a saliency-guided attack that spends more queries to rank word importance.
(3) **A paired comparison between edit types** (Section 5.7): Word substitutions flip more decisions than character noise while requiring roughly half as many edits (26 versus 10 sample-specific flips, $p = 0.011$). In addition, ranking word swaps by model saliency flips more messages than random word swaps under the same budget (33 versus 7, $p = 4 \times 10^{-5}$). Pairing the tests on the same messages provides an honest comparison.
(4) **Low transferability across models** (Section 7): Replaying saved text edits across different models flips almost no samples off the diagonal. Transfer rates remain low overall. The edits appear specific to individual models rather than general. Guided edits transfer slightly better than random edits, but remain ineffective as portable attacks.
(5) **A negative result about what predicts fragility** (Section 5.5): neither overall accuracy nor the measured distance from the decision threshold orders the attack success rate across the three models. The model with the most flips is not the least accurate, and its own probability channel saturates at 0.9999 or above on 800 of its 845 stored originals, so no margin can be read there. The one clear case is the detector that marks almost everything malicious: its score barely varies, so it looks robust for a reason that has nothing to do with robustness.
(6) **A clear negative result**: Under a 15% edit budget, random edits rarely fool these models. For practical deployments, the real concern is initial detection accuracy rather than vulnerability to simple random edits.

Scope and limitations. We do not evaluate white-box attacks with full access to model internal weights, nor do we evaluate adaptive attackers who know the defence beforehand. Our saliency attack selects words using model feedback, but it also uses a larger dictionary than the random word baseline. Therefore, the gap between them is not due to word ordering alone (Section 6). An ablation study in Section 6.1 isolates these factors and shows their individual impact on identical messages. Across the two random attacks, we observe 40 flips in 2,079 messages across 8,047 queries. Because these flip counts are small, the confidence intervals are wide, and we focus on general trends rather than minor numerical differences.

2 RELATED WORK

Language models as email and SMS detectors. Using pre-trained language models without fine-tuning (zero-shot classification) is now a standard baseline for security triage, that is, for sorting incoming messages into harmful and safe. Rojas-Galeano tested models on SpamAssassin without extra training: an F1 score of 90% for Flan-T5 on short emails and 95% for GPT-4 on summarised emails [13]. Eilertsen et al. tried zero-shot and few-shot prompts for phishing detection. Accuracy varied between models, and they asked whether the answers come from what the model already knows or from the examples in the prompt [3]. Koide et al. built a detector from email headers and bodies and reported 99.70% accuracy with GPT-4 [7]. Wang et al. added external web context to SMS triage inside an agent pipeline and reached 98.8% overall accuracy [17]. Thapa et al. studied small language models and found that rewritten emails lower detection performance [15]. Our study is about measurement rules rather than model design. We keep the detector and the prompt fixed and apply careful counting rules to see how text edits change the final decision.

Attacking security text filters. Shafee et al. generated believable text to attack threat-intelligence pipelines. Their text misled the classifiers, producing a 75% false-positive rate when ChatGPT-4o acted as the detector [14]. Kulkarni et al. generated fake phishing pages: small detectors failed, while vision-language models held up better [8]. Our setting is the raw message text, not a web page, and our attacker makes small edits instead of writing new text from scratch. That matches what a real attacker needs, because the victim still has to read the message.

Small text edits (perturbations) and their budgets. Character-level attacks change single letters. DeepWordBug added typos and letter swaps [4], and HotFlip formalized gradient-based character flips [2]. Word-level attacks replace whole words while keeping the meaning. TextFooler searches for synonyms greedily [6], and PWWS ranks words by how much a replacement changes the model's confidence (its saliency) [12]. The TextAttack library puts these methods into standard goals, limits and transformations [10]. We test two search strengths. The first picks a synonym at random from a small table; it stands for a simple attacker and gives a lower bound on evasion. The second ranks word swaps by their measured effect on the model (Section 6), and we call it the guided attack. In Section 6.1 we also run TextFooler's leave-one-out word ranking as a reference arm. We use PWWS and TextFooler to define the search logic, not to compare our numbers with the ones they report.

Cross-model transfer, and how such results should be evaluated. Yuan et al. showed that adversarial text often transfers across different neural models, and built ensembles that attack several models at once [18]. He et al. extracted model parameters to build transferable attacks against a target system [5]. These studies motivate our cross-model transfer matrix in Section 7. In our tests, edits found on one model rarely work on another, because our attacker runs a bounded local search rather than learning directions that carry across models. On statistics, Carlini et al. showed that many robustness evaluations contain flaws and proposed standard practice for threat models [1]. Zimmermann et al. used active tests to find weaknesses in 11 of 13 published defences [19]. Recent work also stresses the need for exact confidence intervals in robustness certificates [16]. We follow that practice: every evasion rate in this paper reports its numerator, its total count and an exact Wilson interval [11].

3 THREAT MODEL AND MEASUREMENT PROTOCOL

3.1 Adversary

The attacker controls the message text and nothing else: no access to the model weights, gradients, logits or detector code, and no way to retrain it. The attacker also wants the message to stay readable, so the edit budget is capped: at most 15% of the message's units (characters for the character-level attack, whitespace-separated tokens for the word-level attack) may change, and the change is measured, not estimated.

Two channels, reported separately. Not every attack in this paper assumes the same interface, and the paper never adds them together. The *verdict channel* returns the one-word generated answer: malicious or benign, one bit per query. That is what a spammer probing a filter receives, and it is the information source for the character and random-word attacks (Section 5). The *probability channel* also returns $P(\text{malicious})$ — here by scoring the two permitted answer tokens — and only the saliency-guided attack uses it (Section 6), because a ranking needs a number and one bit per candidate cannot give one. Every row in every table records which channel produced it, the two channels are never mixed inside one comparison, and the disagreement between them is reported on its own (Section 9). The ablation of Section 6.1 holds the information source fixed across arms, precisely so that the cost of dropping from the probability channel to the verdict channel is measured rather than assumed.

The verdict-only adversary is deliberately weak, and for that reason its ASR is a lower bound. An attacker with weight access, an embedding-space attack or a saliency-guided word search would do better. A weak adversary is useful precisely because a flip under it is unambiguously bad news for the detector: nothing exotic happened, the message simply stopped looking suspicious.

3.2 The four rules that make an ASR quotable

Rule 1 — count only the messages the model had caught, and check them again. Only messages the clean model classified *malicious* are attacked. The original text is queried again inside the attack run instead of trusting the baseline label, and a sample whose original no longer reads as malicious is *excluded* from the total rather than counted as a failed attack. In our runs this happened 52 times, and each exclusion is recorded with its reason.

Where the 52 exclusions come from. They fall into exactly two kinds. Forty-three are samples that the saliency attack's probability channel read as benign on the original — all of them on Qwen2.5-3B, a channel problem discussed in Section 9. The other nine are word-attack samples whose edited text came out identical to the original, so no edit was made and there was nothing to score. No original was dropped for any other reason: the verdict channel never re-read a baseline-caught message as benign, so the character and saliency runs on the other two models exclude nothing at all.

Rule 2 — the same prompt on both sides. The baseline and the attack call the identical message template, including the sample's own task description, so an email is never scored with the SMS prompt. A baseline-versus-attack comparison across two different prompts would measure the prompt, not the attack.

Rule 3 — one shared budget, measured exactly. The 15% budget is a single allowance for the whole edit, not one per operation, and the edit rate is the exact Levenshtein distance (the smallest number of single-character insertions, deletions and substitutions that turns one string into the other) divided by the length of the original. Both details matter. Giving each operation its own allowance let the real rate reach 22% while the reported budget was 15%; and estimating the distance from a 'difflib' opcode tally reported 204 edits for 56 deleted characters on a repetitive message, because 'difflib' does not compute a minimal edit script.

Rule 4 — name the similarity you actually computed. We report word-set Jaccard overlap and call it Jaccard. No sentence-similarity model is used anywhere in this study, so no BERTScore is claimed. For the character attack we add that Jaccard is the wrong tool: a look-alike substitution changes the token, so word-set overlap collapses even though a human reads the same message.

3.3 Perturbations: what each attack changes

Character level. Four operations share the budget: look-alike substitution (the Latin letters 'a', 'e', 'o', 'p', 'c', 'x', 'y', 'i', 's' replaced by Cyrillic characters that print the same), random deletion, random insertion of lowercase letters, and swapping two neighbouring characters (counting as two edits).

Word level. Four operations share the budget: replacing a word with one of its listed synonyms from a hand-written 14-entry table, word deletion, word duplication, and word swap. The synonym table is deliberately small, which weakens the attack and strengthens the negative result.

How many attempts, and what that costs. The two random attacks give each sample up to three independent attempts from a per-sample seeded random generator, stopping at the first flip, so one message can cost one to four queries: one for the re-queried original plus one per attempt. On the recorded runs that comes to 3.9 queries per message and 8,047 queries for the 2,079 attacked messages — the number of messages and the number of queries are different quantities and are reported separately throughout. The

saliency attack is not attempt-based: it probes every candidate position once and then re-queries after each accepted edit, 22.9 queries per message on average. The attempt column in every row carries how many tries a message actually took, which is why the count above is measured rather than assumed.

Every attempt's edited text, verdict, edit count and rate are written to the per-sample CSV, so the tables can be rebuilt without the model.

3.4 Statistics

An ASR of k flips out of n attacks is a share of a fixed number of attempts. We report the 95% Wilson score interval, which stays inside $[0, 1]$ and, more importantly, does not collapse at the edge: a row with $k = 0$ of $n = 188$ has upper bound 2.0%, not 0%. As a cross-check we also compute a percentile bootstrap over the same rows (10,000 resamples, fixed seed), which agrees with Wilson wherever $k > 0$; where $k = 0$ the bootstrap collapses to $[0, 0]$ and we quote Wilson instead. The interval covers sampling variation over *messages*, not variation of the perturbation seed; measuring the latter needs a second run over the same samples, which is what the seed sweep below does.

Seed variation. The intervals above cover variation over messages, not over the perturbation generator. The runner therefore takes `--seed` and a sweep driver (`src/run_seed_sweep.py`) reruns one arm at several seeds, so the spread between seeds can be reported next to the sampling interval rather than absorbed into it. The sweep is implemented; its cells are not part of the numbers in this version, and Section 9 lists that as a gap rather than implying the intervals cover it.

4 EXPERIMENTAL SETUP

Data. We use two sorting tasks. *SMS smishing* uses the UCI SMS Spam Collection (5,574 messages, 747 labelled spam), with spam treated as malicious. The task label is therefore "SMS spam/smishing"; the collection's spam class is mostly scam and prize messages rather than messages that steal passwords, and we state that as a limit on what the label means instead of hiding it. *Phishing email* uses the `zefang-liu/phishing-email-dataset` text column, filtered to messages between 16 and 3,000 characters and balanced-sampled to 1,000 benign and 1,000 phishing rows with a fixed seed.

Splits. The evaluation split is balanced and frozen: 200 benign and 200 malicious rows per task, 800 rows in total, drawn with seed 42. The split is identical in every run, and its hash is checked by the artefact's setup step, so a run that uses different data fails before it can report a number. Attacks are launched on the caught subset *of this evaluation split*, which is a within-sample design: the same 800 rows supply both the baseline and the attack set. We say so because it means the ASR is not an out-of-sample estimate; it is a conditional measurement on the messages the model got right, which is what Rule 1 defines.

Models. We evaluate three open instruction-tuned models, none compressed at inference: Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct, SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct and Phi-3.5-mini-instruct (3.8B). A fourth model, Llama-3.2-3B-Instruct, was planned but sits behind a licence acceptance and is not part of any number reported here.

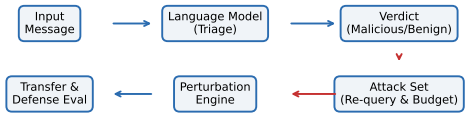


Figure 1: The evaluation pipeline. A clean message is classified by the model. If the verdict is malicious, the message enters the attack set. The perturbation engine applies edits under budget and re-queries the model. The results are then evaluated for transfer and defense robustness.

Inference. All models are served behind one OpenAI-compatible endpoint and queried with the same list of messages. Generation is greedy (temperature 0), capped at 8 new tokens, with a single-word answer parser that returns malicious, benign, or *unparsed*; unparsed answers are counted separately and never guessed. In the runs reported here, no answer failed to parse. Models are loaded at half precision on one T4 GPU with automatic device placement.

Compute and cost. One full run — clean baseline on 800 rows for three models, construction of the attack set, and both attack modes for all three models — takes 37.1 minutes on a single free-tier T4. The reporting step is a separate pass over the per-sample CSVs and runs on CPU.

Evaluation pipeline. Figure 1 shows the full pipeline. A message is classified by the model. If the verdict is malicious, the message enters the attack set. The perturbation engine applies edits and re-queries the model. The results are then evaluated for transfer to other models and for defences.

Reproducibility. Splits, prompt, decoding and per-sample perturbation seeds are fixed. The study was run twice from start to finish (two independent GPU sessions); comparing the two runs sample by sample, joined on sample id, gives identical attacked ids and identical success flags in all six result files, with differences only in empty cells of the excluded rows. The second run is the one whose outputs are reported here.

5 RESULTS

5.1 Clean baseline, and what it already tells us

Table 1 is the clean zero-shot baseline, before any attack. Two rows matter more than the accuracy column.

Phi-3.5-mini is a cautious detector on email. Its precision is high (0.896) but it misses 80 of the 200 phishing messages, a catch rate of 60.0%. It is the model that leaves the most malicious mail in the analyst's queue before any attack happens.

SmolLM2-1.7B is a degenerate detector. It reaches a catch rate of 98.5% on phishing email, but its precision is 0.510 and its confusion matrix shows 189 false positives against 11 true negatives on the benign class: it calls nearly every message malicious. A detector that says *malicious* almost always is hard to flip towards

benign, and every robustness number for it has to be read against that fact.

Qwen2.5-3B is the strongest and most balanced classifier of the three (F1 0.923 on email, 0.857 on SMS).

5.2 Character-level evasion

Table 2 reports the character-level attack. Of 1,044 caught messages attacked, 12 flipped: an aggregate of 1.1%. Per row the ASR lies between 0.0% and 5.0%, and under a 15% budget the mean fraction of characters actually edited was 13.3–13.6%, with no row above the budget (maximum 13.6%).

The highest row is Phi-3.5-mini on phishing email: 6 flips in 120 attacked messages, 5.0% (95% CI 2.3–10.5). This is the model with the lowest catch rate on that task. The model that catches 95.5% of email (Qwen2.5-3B) flips once in 191 attacks, and on SMS it flips zero times in 188 attempts. A zero is reported as a bounded measurement, not as proof: the Wilson upper bound for that row is 2.0%.

5.3 Word-level evasion

Table 3 applies the same budget to whole words. Of 1,035 caught messages, 28 flipped — more than twice the character-level count — while changing only 6.2–9.2% of words, roughly half the unit budget the character attack spent. Word-set Jaccard stays at 0.916–0.950, so the messages are 92–95% word-identical to what the model had already caught.

The ranking changes. The character attack leaves Qwen2.5-3B on SMS at zero flips; the word attack flips 6 of 186 (3.2%, CI 1.5–6.9). A replaced word carries meaning that a single letter does not: swapping a suspicious verb for a neutral synonym, or deleting the word that carried the urgency, moves a verdict that typo noise leaves alone.

5.4 Budget accounting

Table 4 is the accounting check, and Figure 2 draws the same accounting instead of summing it: one point per model, task and attack, with the budget spent on the horizontal axis. Both modes stay inside the shared budget, and the word attack reaches a similar number of flips with about half the units changed. That imbalance is the paper's main measured point: for these models, *what* is changed matters more than *how much*.

5.5 What predicts fragility

The order across models is not explained by accuracy. SmolLM2-1.7B has the lowest accuracy of the three and flips 22 of its 1,144 attacked rows; Qwen2.5-3B is the most accurate and flips 17 of 1,091; Phi-3.5-mini, neither the best nor the worst on accuracy, flips 47 of 845. The model with the most flips is therefore not the least accurate model, and the least accurate model is not the one that flips most.

The distance from the decision threshold is measurable on the stored rows, and it does not order the same list either. Every attack row carries the probability the model gave its original text on the two-token channel the saliency attack uses, so the mean margin ($p_{\text{orig}} - 0.5$) over the messages that channel also called malicious can be read off per model (`results/margin_table.csv`, from `src/analyze_margin.py`): 0.449 for Qwen2.5-3B, 0.482 for SmolLM2-1.7B and 0.494 for Phi-3.5-mini. The widest of the three belongs to the model that flips most, and the narrowest to Qwen2.5-3B, which flips least. On Phi-3.5-mini the number should not be trusted at all: 800 of its 845 stored originals score at least 0.9999, so the channel saturates and returns no margin to compare. The ordering has also been attributed to proximity to the decision boundary; the stored scores do not support that, and this paper does not claim it.

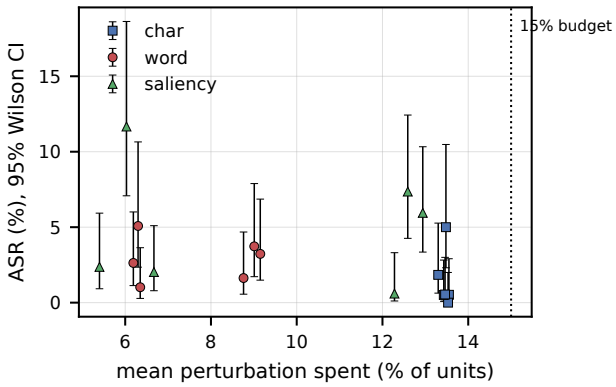


Figure 2: Each point is one (model, task, attack) cell: the edit actually spent on the horizontal axis, the ASR with its 95% Wilson interval on the vertical axis. The dotted line is the 15% budget. Points to the left of a vertical pair are the same amount of visible change bought at half the unit cost – the word attack's advantage is horizontal as well as vertical.

What the scores do support is narrower, and inside one channel. Where the probability channel does flip a message, that message started closer to the threshold than the ones the channel leaves alone: mean 0.792 against 0.959 for Qwen2.5-3B and 0.927 against 0.998 for Phi-3.5-mini. SmolLM2-1.7B never flips on that channel at all (0 of 1,144), although its generated verdict changes 22 times — a disagreement between the two channels of the kind that Section 9 reports, not a margin result. Its scores sit in a narrow band (median 0.984), which is the near-constant rule seen in the baseline table: an edit has little score to move, so the model can look robust, in the sense a deployment cares about, only by accident.

5.6 Interval discipline

Figure 3 collects all twelve random-attack cells and the three saliency cells in one panel, with the interval drawn on every bar, so the comparison below can be read at a glance rather than row by row.

Because the flip counts are small, we do not rank models on point estimates. Of the twelve pairs of rows sharing a task and one of the two random attack modes, 9 of 12 have intervals that overlap by more than half the narrower interval's width, so within-task ordering is suggestive rather than established. The exceptions are informative. The three pairs that overlap by less than half the narrower width all involve Phi-3.5-mini on phishing email, and the two with the least overlap are the same comparison from both sides: under the character attack, Phi-3.5-mini's interval overlaps

Table 1: Clean zero-shot baseline on the frozen 800-row evaluation split (400 rows per task, 200 malicious). "Catch" is recall on the malicious class and is the denominator every ASR in this paper is conditional on.

Task	Model	Acc.	Prec.	Rec.	F1	TP/FP	Catch
SMS smishing	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	0.772	0.751	0.815	0.782	163/54	81.5%
	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	0.843	0.787	0.940	0.857	188/51	94.0%
	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	0.525	0.514	0.925	0.661	185/175	92.5%
Phishing email	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	0.765	0.895	0.600	0.719	120/14	60.0%
	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	0.920	0.892	0.955	0.923	191/23	95.5%
	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	0.520	0.510	0.985	0.672	197/189	98.5%

Table 2: Character-level evasion under a 15% edit budget. ASR is flips / samples attacked, where only samples the clean model classified malicious are attacked and each original is re-queried. CI is a 95% Wilson interval.

Task	Model	Attacked	Flips	ASR	95% CI	Pert.	Jacc.	Catch
SMS smishing	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	163	3	1.8%	0.6–5.3	13.3%	0.328	81.5%
	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	188	0	0.0%	0.0–2.0	13.5%	0.322	94.0%
	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	185	1	0.5%	0.1–3.0	13.5%	0.317	92.5%
Phishing email	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	120	6	5.0%	2.3–10.5	13.5%	0.322	60.0%
	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	191	1	0.5%	0.1–2.9	13.6%	0.303	95.5%
	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	197	1	0.5%	0.1–2.8	13.4%	0.311	98.5%

Table 3: Word-level evasion under the same 15% budget (synonym swap, deletion, duplication, swap). Jaccard is word-set overlap; no semantic-similarity model is used anywhere in this study.

Task	Model	Attacked	Flips	ASR	95% CI	Pert.	Jacc.	Catch
SMS smishing	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	161	6	3.7%	1.7–7.9	9.0%	0.918	81.5%
	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	186	6	3.2%	1.5–6.9	9.2%	0.916	94.0%
	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	184	3	1.6%	0.6–4.7	8.8%	0.916	92.5%
Phishing email	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	118	6	5.1%	2.4–10.7	6.3%	0.945	60.0%
	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	190	5	2.6%	1.1–6.0	6.2%	0.950	95.5%
	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	196	2	1.0%	0.3–3.6	6.3%	0.948	98.5%

Table 4: Edit budget actually spent, by attack mode. The budget is one shared 15% allowance per sample; the measured rate is the exact Levenshtein distance divided by the original length (characters or words).

Mode	Samples	Flips	Mean pert.	Max pert.
Character	1044	12	13.5%	13.6%
Word	1035	28	7.6%	9.2%
Saliency	1001	46	9.3%	12.9%
Total		86		

Qwen2.5-3B's by 21.3% and SmolLM2-1.7B's by 18.7% of the narrower width. That is the one model whose catch rate on the task is far below the other two (60.0% against 95.5%), which is the difference that Section 5.5 turns on.

What the intervals do establish is magnitude, and the magnitude depends on the search. No random-edit cell exceeds 10.7% at its upper bound; the saliency-guided cells of Section 6 reach 18.6%. The claim "under a 15% edit budget a random edit leaves these models close to robust" survives the uncertainty; the claim "model A is more robust than model B" does not, for most pairs, and neither claim extends to a better search.

5.7 Is the difference between the two modes real?

Comparing a 3.7% cell with a 1.8% cell as if they were independent samples is the wrong test: both attacks ran on the *same* messages, so the flips are paired, and the pairing is what makes a small difference measurable. We pair the per-sample outcomes on the message identifier and report the counts of messages the two attacks disagree on, an exact McNemar test, and a paired bootstrap of the difference in risk over messages.

Pairing the two attacks on the messages both of them attacked, the word attack flips 26 messages the character attack leaves alone, and the character attack flips 10 that the word attack leaves alone (exact McNemar $p = 0.011$ over the pooled discordant counts). Per cell, 1 of 6 shows a significant paired difference at $p < 0.05$: SMS smishing/Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct. The rest are underpowered rather

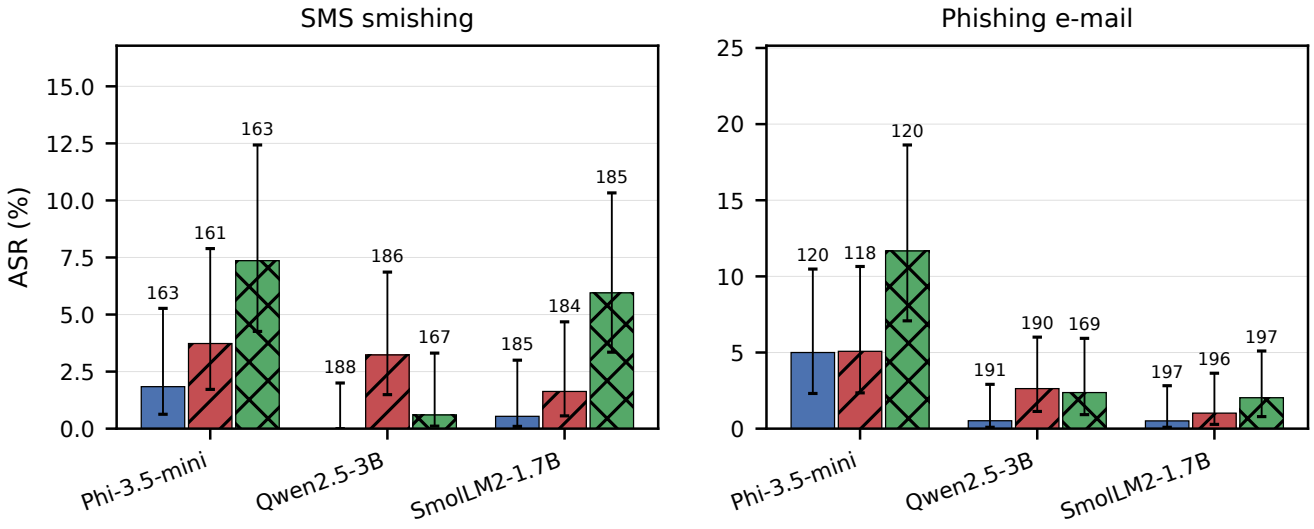


Figure 3: Attack success rate per model, task and attack mode, with 95% Wilson intervals on the flip count. Solid blue bars are the character attack, hatched red bars the word attack, and green cross-hatched bars the saliency-guided word attack of Section 6, which is drawn here for comparison but costs 22.9 model queries per message against 3.9 for the two random attacks, so the bars are not a comparison at equal cost. The number above each interval is the total count: the messages that model had caught on the clean text and that were therefore attacked. A cell at zero is drawn with its interval, not as a point at the origin, because 0/188 is a bounded measurement rather than a proof of robustness.

than contradictory, and the pooled test is a description of the direction because the cells reuse the same messages across models.

The honest reading is narrower than the raw table suggests. The direction is consistent — word-level edits flip more messages than character-level ones in five of six cells and never fewer — but only one cell is significant on its own, because there the character attack flipped nothing at all. What survives is a pooled statement about this corpus and these three models, not a per-model ranking, and the interval widths in Table 5 say the same thing.

6 WHERE IS THE MODEL FRAGILE? A SALIENCY-GUIDED WORD ATTACK

The word attack of Section 5 picks its replacement at random from a small synonym table. It answers only whether *any* word-level edit breaks the model, and leaves the location of the weakness unmeasured: a flip caused by deleting the word *urgent* and a flip caused by replacing the word *the* are the same event in that accounting. This section asks the sharper question, and pays for the answer in queries.

Method. We use the ordering of PWWS [12]. For a message x that the model reads as malicious with probability p_0, a content word i and a candidate replacement w, let $p_{i,w} = P(\text{malicious} \mid x \text{ with word } i \text{ replaced by } w)$ be measured with the same prompt. The importance of a word (its saliency) and the priority of a substitution are

$$S_i = p_0 - p_{i,w}, \qquad \phi_{i,w} = \alpha\,\tilde{S}_i + (1-\alpha)\,p_{i,w}, \tag{1}$$

where $\tilde{S}_i$ is S_i divided by the largest saliency in the message and $\alpha = 0.5$. Substitutions are applied greedily in descending ϕ; after each accepted edit the verdict is queried again, and the attack stops at the first flip or when the shared 15% word budget is used up.

The normalisation of S matters. With raw saliency and $\alpha = 0.5$, $\phi_{i,w} = \frac{1}{2}(p_0 - p_{i,w}) + \frac{1}{2}p_{i,w} = \frac{1}{2}p_0$ for *every* candidate: the ranking flattens to a constant, and the greedy loop then applies substitutions in whatever order the words happen to appear in the message. Because p_0 is common to all candidates, only the scale of S matters, and the scale is exactly what the normalisation fixes. The unit test that guards against that defect (`tests/check_saliency.py`) checks that a high-saliency word outranks a neutral one at $\alpha = 0.5$.

Candidate replacements. Two sources, recorded for every substitution: a curated security word list (66 entries: *verify* → *confirm/validate*, *prize* → *award/reward*, …) and WordNet [9] synonyms ordered by how often the word occurs. The ordering matters more than it looks: WordNet's third sense of a word is where synonyms stop being paraphrases (*tone* → *timber*), and such a substitution would be counted as meaning-preserving when it is not. Multi-word replacements are excluded so that the 15% budget counts words and nothing else. Candidates are capped at two per position and twelve positions per message, which is what keeps the query cost bounded.

Two channels. This attack needs a number, not a paragraph: at every candidate it asks the endpoint for $P(\text{malicious})$, obtained by scoring the two permitted answer tokens in one forward pass. The other two attacks read the model's generated one-word reply instead. Those are two channels of the same model, and comparing

Table 5: Paired comparison of two attack modes on the same messages. Only the discordant counts carry information about the difference: A-only flips happened under the first mode and not the second, B-only the reverse. The p-value is an exact McNemar test (binomial on the discordant counts); the interval is a percentile bootstrap over messages of the paired risk difference.

A vs B	Task	Model	Paired	A flips	B flips	Risk diff.	95% CI	A/B only	p
saliency vs word	Phishing email	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	118	14	6	+6.8	+1.7 to +11.9	9/1	0.021
saliency vs word	Phishing email	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	169	4	1	+1.8	-0.6 to +4.7	4/1	0.375
saliency vs word	Phishing email	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	196	3	2	+0.5	-1.0 to +2.0	2/1	1.000
saliency vs word	SMS smishing	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	161	12	6	+3.7	+0.6 to +7.4	7/1	0.070
saliency vs word	SMS smishing	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	167	1	1	+0.0	-1.8 to +1.8	1/1	1.000
saliency vs word	SMS smishing	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	184	11	3	+4.3	+1.1 to +8.2	10/2	0.039
word vs char	Phishing email	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	118	6	6	+0.0	-5.1 to +5.1	5/5	1.000
word vs char	Phishing email	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	190	5	1	+2.1	+0.0 to +4.7	5/1	0.219
word vs char	Phishing email	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	196	2	1	+0.5	-1.0 to +2.5	2/1	1.000
word vs char	SMS smishing	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	161	6	3	+1.9	-1.2 to +5.0	5/2	0.453
word vs char	SMS smishing	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	186	6	0	+3.2	+1.1 to +5.9	6/0	0.031
word vs char	SMS smishing	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	184	3	1	+1.1	-1.1 to +3.3	3/1	0.625

their ASRs without checking that they agree would be comparing a ruler with a scale. Every stored saliency row is therefore re-scored through the verdict channel, and Table 6 reports the verdict; the artefact keeps both columns and the probability-channel count, and we do not treat a disagreement between them as a bug to be tuned away — it is a fact about the model.

The probability channel also has a failure mode worth recording, because it is silent. The answer tokens are chosen per tokenizer, and Phi-3.5 encodes " malicious" as three tokens whose first element is the bare whitespace marker that " benign" also begins with. Scoring the first token of each answer therefore compares the space against itself: both logits are identical, $P(\text{malicious}) = 0.5$ for every message, and a saliency attack built on it finds nothing to rank and no flip to report. The endpoint now skips the shared prefix, and raises an error rather than returning a constant when the two answers cannot be told apart. The saliency numbers for that model in this version come from the corrected scoring; its earlier all-zero result was an artefact of the bug.

Query accounting. Unlike the random attack, this one costs a measured number of model calls: roughly two per probed position, plus one check per accepted edit. Probabilities come from a dedicated endpoint that scores the two permitted answer tokens in a single forward pass over the prompt, batched across candidates; the per-sample count is stored with the result, so the comparison in Table 6 is between attacks whose cost is on the record. The saliency attack spends 22.9 queries per message, six times what the random attack spends per message (Section 3), for 1.6 times as many flips. The paper therefore does not claim equal cost.

What the comparison isolates, and what it does not. Three things change between Table 6's two rows at once: the *ordering* (random draw versus saliency), the *candidate set* (a 14-entry hand-written table versus a security word list plus WordNet), and the *information* (a one-bit verdict versus $P(\text{malicious})$). The table therefore supports only the combination: saliency-ordered substitution over a security vocabulary breaks more messages per unit of edit than a random draw over a small table. It does not show that ordering alone is responsible, and it cannot say what the probability channel is worth. Section 6.1 specifies the experiment that separates the three.

At the same word budget, the random attack flips 28 of 1035 caught messages (2.7%) and the saliency attack flips 46 of 1001 (4.6%). Each saliency-attacked message costs a mean of 23 model queries. The random word attack is not a single draw either: it requeries every original and spends one query per attempt, so its 1,035 messages cost 3,927 queries, 3.8 each. The saliency attacker buys its extra flips with about 6.1 times as many calls, and that price is part of the claim, not a footnote to it. The saliency attack also edits MORE, not less: 9.3% of words against 7.6% for the random attack. Normalising by the budget actually spent, it buys 0.493 of a flip per percent of words edited against 0.355, so the advantage is real but smaller than the raw ASR ratio. Both numbers are pooled over different candidate vocabularies and, after the exclusions, over different message sets, so the denominator is 1,001 for the saliency attack and 1,035 for the random one; the paired comparison of Section 5.7 is the only place where the two are measured on the same messages. Pooled query accounting, kept separate from the message count because the two are different numbers: the character attack sends 1,044 caught messages in 4,120 queries, the word attack 1,035 in 3,927, so the random attacks together send 2,079 messages in 8,047 queries (3.9 each), and the saliency attack sends 1,001 messages in 22,964 queries (22.9 each).

6.1 A matched-vocabulary, matched-budget ablation

Table 6 cannot attribute its difference to any single cause, because ordering, candidate set and information all change together. The comparison below (called an ablation, because it removes one factor at a time) holds two of the three fixed in every contrast, so each contrast has one explanation. It is implemented in `src/ablation_common.py`, exercised by `tests/check_ablation.py`, and run; its contrasts are tabulated in Table 7 and described in the paragraph that follows, both generated from `results/ablation_contrasts.csv`. It is an ablation on a matched subsample, not on the full attack set,

Table 6: Saliency-guided (PWWS-style) word attack next to the uniform-random word attack, both inside the same 15% word budget. Both spend a measured number of model queries: the random attack re-queries every original and keeps drawing until a flip or three attempts, the saliency attack probes every candidate. Per-sample query counts are stored with each row.

Task	Model	Attacked	Flips	ASR	95% CI	Pert.	Jacc.
SMS smishing	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct (saliency)	163	12	7.4%	4.3–12.4	12.6%	0.773
	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct (word)	161	6	3.7%	1.7–7.9	9.0%	0.918
	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct (saliency)	167	1	0.6%	0.1–3.3	12.3%	0.778
	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct (word)	186	6	3.2%	1.5–6.9	9.2%	0.916
	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct (saliency)	185	11	5.9%	3.4–10.3	12.9%	0.768
	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct (word)	184	3	1.6%	0.6–4.7	8.8%	0.916
Phishing email	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct (saliency)	120	14	11.7%	7.1–18.6	6.0%	0.867
	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct (word)	118	6	5.1%	2.4–10.7	6.3%	0.945
	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct (saliency)	169	4	2.4%	0.9–5.9	5.4%	0.876
	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct (word)	190	5	2.6%	1.1–6.0	6.2%	0.950
	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct (saliency)	197	4	2.0%	0.8–5.1	6.7%	0.851
	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct (word)	196	2	1.0%	0.3–3.6	6.3%	0.948

and every count it reports is paired on the messages the two arms share.

One probe phase, then a difference in policy. Every arm attacks the same messages, with the same candidate set, and pays the same probe cost before it edits anything: one query for the original, then one query per single substitution candidate, capped identically at the same number of calls per message for every arm (24 in the configuration the runner reports, and the cap it used travels with every row). The reported cells are the first 400 eligible messages of each model, and 400 covers the largest eligible set (382 messages, smollm2-1.7b), so every arm attacks exactly the messages the attack tables report on. The cap was not reached in practice — the highest mean spend of any arm is 23.3 of its 24 calls — so one arm differs from another only in policy: what it does with those measurements. Matching the budget by construction rather than by assumption is the point: a random-order arm pays exactly the $1 + |C|$ calls that a saliency arm pays before either starts substituting, so a difference in flips cannot be a difference in cost. The realised count is still stored per row, because a cap that is matched on paper and used up early in practice would be the same error as an unmatched total.

Four cells and one stronger attack. The factorial crosses the two orderings with the two information sources: *random-prob* (random order, probability information), *saliency-prob* (the attack of this section, so the cell doubles as its re-implementation), *random-verdict* (random order, one-bit information) and *group-verdict* (a binary search over candidate *subsets*: apply half, query once, recurse into the half that flipped). A fifth arm, *textfooler-prob*, implements TextFooler's search [6] rather than PWWS's: word importance is leave-one-out — each word replaced by a placeholder, importance the drop in $P(\text{malicious})$, doubled when the leave-one-out text has already flipped, which is the correction in the paper's Eq. 2 without which a word the model has already lost looks unimportant — then words are substituted in descending importance with all of one word's candidates predicted in one batch, accepting a flip that passes the meaning check and otherwise keeping the candidate that lowers the malicious confidence most. It costs one extra query per position, so it is matched by the cap rather than by construction.

The contrasts are then read as: *random-prob* vs *saliency-prob* is the ordering effect with vocabulary and budget held fixed; *random-prob* vs *random-verdict* is what probability access is worth to an attacker who cannot rank; *random-verdict* vs *group-verdict* is how much of that a one-bit answer can recover by searching instead of ranking; and *random-prob* against the recorded random word attack of Section 5 isolates the candidate set, which is the only thing those two do not share.

Meaning preservation is a constraint, not a claim. Every arm sends candidates through a lexical paraphrase test (WordNet-based, since this study ships no sentence-embedding model) and records, for every applied edit, the similarity the test used along with literal retention and paraphrase coverage. TextFooler's arm turns the test on by default at a recorded threshold, because without a meaning constraint it is not TextFooler. All three scores travel with every row, so a reader can re-derive an acceptance decision at another threshold instead of taking ours.

What a one-bit attacker can and cannot do. PWWS's ordering needs a single number per candidate. A verdict has one bit, and that bit is spent by the first flip, so a verdict-only arm *cannot rank* by saliency at all. Its targeted policy is therefore a search over subsets, and the comparison is reported as how much of the saliency advantage survives when the attacker holds only the bit — not as a like-for-like ranking comparison, which would be measuring an impossible attacker.

Calibration, seeds and status. The meaning threshold and α are tuned on the calibration slice, which is disjoint from both the evaluation and the attack slice (`src/build_splits.py` asserts the disjointness), and never on the messages whose ASR is reported. Every arm takes a seed and the sweep driver re-runs it at several, so ordering effects can be separated from seed noise. One command per arm runs it (`python src/run_ablation.py --model <key> --arm <arm>`), and the per-sample records are written in the same

schema as the other attacks, which is what lets the paired test of Section 5.7 be applied to the ablation without new code.

Table 7 reports each contrast on the messages its two arms share. With the candidate set, the probe phase and the query cap held fixed, ordering by saliency flips 17 messages the uniform draw does not, against 0 in the other direction (exact McNemar $p = 0.0000$ over 1001 paired messages). Replacing the probability channel with the one-bit verdict loses 26 messages that survive on probabilities and wins 14 the probability arm misses ($p = 0.0807$, 1001 pairs). Searching over candidate subsets instead of ranking under the same bit recovers 6 messages the ranking arm misses, against 0 in the other direction ($p = 0.0312$, 1044 pairs). Against the 14-entry hand-written table, the lexicon plus WordNet flips 32 messages the small table does not, against 1 ($p = 0.0000$, 1044 pairs). TextFooler's leave-one-out importance ranking flips 0 messages PWWS's saliency ranking does not, against 20 in the other direction ($p = 0.0000$, 1001 pairs). The published attack's ranking therefore is not uniformly stronger on these messages, which is why it is reported as a reference point rather than as a fifth cell. These are pooled counts over model and task, and the cells reuse messages across models, so they describe a direction rather than a confirmatory test; the per-cell pairs are in the artefact.

Reading the five contrasts. The ordering contrast is the one this section was built for, and it is the cleanest result in the paper: with the candidate set, the probe phase and the cap held fixed, every message the two arms disagreed on went to saliency ordering. The candidate-set contrast is nearly as large again, which is the uncomfortable half of the finding — most of the difference between Table 6's two rows is vocabulary, not intelligence, so the unmatched comparison overstates what ordering buys. The probability channel — the thing a saliency attack is supposed to need — is the weakest of the three: an attacker holding only the one-bit verdict loses messages in one direction and wins a few in the other, and the difference does not reach significance at this sample size. Searching subsets instead of ranking recovers a handful of the messages that the bit costs, which is what the theory predicts, because one bit cannot rank.

The fifth contrast needs its budget read out loud before its number is quoted. TextFooler's leave-one-out importance spends 23.0 of the 24 calls per message measuring word importance, where the saliency arm spends 20.6 and still has edits left to spend its calls on; the extra query per position is what the published search costs, and under a cap that has to cover both the probe and the substitutions, it is paid for out of the substitutions. So the contrast says what a query-starved importance ranking achieves inside this cap — not that the published attack is weaker, which this design cannot test. It is reported as a reference point and not as a fifth cell for that reason, and the arm's per-sample records carry the realised query count so a reader can check the accounting rather than take it on faith.

7 DO THE PERTURBATIONS TRANSFER ACROSS MODELS?

A single-model ASR answers a narrow question: how much does *this* model cost an attacker who can query it. That is the right question for a targeted campaign and the wrong one for a defender choosing a model, because an attacker who cannot query the deployed model will instead build perturbations against something they can download. If those perturbations do not survive the move, the weakness measured in Section 5 belongs to three specific checkpoints rather than to the task.

Protocol. We generate no new perturbations. Every text produced by the three attacks — character, word and saliency — is replayed, unchanged, against every other model, with the same prompt, the same answer parser and temperature zero. The saliency rows are the ones worth having: that edit was chosen against the source model's own measured probabilities, so its cell asks whether the choice survives a different decision boundary, where a random edit only asks whether the model is noisy in the same way as its neighbour. Two counting rules make the resulting numbers comparable with the single-model ones:

- **The target owns the denominator.** A perturbation "transfers" only if the target model read the *original* text as malicious and the *edited* text as benign. A message the target never flagged cannot be evaded, and scoring it as a failed transfer would punish the target for being wrong on the clean text — the opposite of robustness.
- **Two subsets, one tabulated.** The *applied* subset contains every perturbation the source actually applied; its denominator is how often the target caught those originals, so it measures how well the perturbation *family* travels. The *flipped-source* subset keeps only the perturbations that fooled the source — the classic transfer matrix — and it is what the literature reports, but at this scale it holds one to six candidates per cell, so its cells carry no denominator worth an interval. We tabulate the applied subset and keep the classic one in the artefact.

The faithfulness check. Replaying a model's own perturbations must reproduce its single-model ASR exactly — same text, same prompt, deterministic decoder — and a mismatch there would invalidate every off-diagonal cell. We run that replay as part of the same pass (`run_transfer.py --include-self`), and we compare it against the attack tables rather than against itself: the stored flip flag from the attack run is the claim, the replayed verdict is the evidence. Every diagonal cell agrees. This is what makes the off-diagonal cells a measurement: the replay path is the same code, prompt and parser that produced Table 3, so a transferred flip cannot come from the test setup. It is a weaker statement than it looks, and worth saying plainly: agreement shows the replay is faithful, not that the decoder is deterministic in general — greedy decoding is reproducible on one GPU build, and a cell could drift on another.

On the applied subset 22 of 36 off-diagonal cells have a nonzero transfer rate, and every cell has a denominator worth an interval. Among the cells with at least ten caught originals, the highest rate is SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct → Phi-3.5-mini-instruct on Phishing email under the saliency attack: 5 of 120 caught originals flipped (4.2%, 95% CI 1.8–9.4). The self-replay is the check that makes the rest of the table readable: each model's own perturbations went through the same path a second time, and its flip count is compared with the one the attack recorded. 18 diagonal cells covering 3,080

Table 7: Matched-vocabulary, matched-budget ablation of Section 6.1. Every contrast holds the candidate set, the probe phase and the 24-call cap fixed and varies one thing; A and B are the two arms, and positive A-only means the first arm flipped messages the second did not. Counts are pooled over model and task; the per-cell pairs are in `results/ablation_contrasts.csv`.

Contrast	Isolates	Paired	A flips	B flips	A-only	B-only	p
candidates	candidate set	1044	45	14	32	1	0.0000
oracle	oracle	1001	44	32	26	14	0.0807
ordering	ordering	1001	61	44	17	0	0.0000
search	search under one bit	1044	51	45	6	0	0.0312
stronger	search rule	1001	41	61	0	20	0.0000

rows were replayed, and every one reproduces the single-model ASR exactly.

Table 8 reports the applied subset only, for all three attack modes; the classic flipped-source matrix lives in the artefact, where its small denominators cannot be mistaken for a rate.

8 TWO DEFENCES THAT NEED NO TRAINING

If the mechanism of an evasion is understood, a cheap fix should blunt it. We test two defences that can be applied after the model is trained, requiring no fine-tuning, no extra data and no change to the deployed weights, and we measure them on the *same* stored perturbations the attacks produced, so the comparison is like for like.

D1: input normalisation. The text is NFKC-normalised (a standard Unicode cleanup); invisible and format characters are removed; Cyrillic and Greek look-alike characters are folded back to their ASCII equivalents; and whitespace is collapsed. This targets exactly the mechanism of the character attack: the model sees a different token where a human sees the same word. It should therefore rescue character-level evasions and do almost nothing for word-level ones — and that null result is evidence that the two attack families fail for different reasons. The transform is idempotent (running it twice changes nothing the second time), which is checked in `tests/check_defense.py`; a transform that was not idempotent would make the "defended" number an artefact of running it twice.

D2: re-thresholding under a false-positive budget. The model's $P(\text{malicious})$ is compared against a threshold τ instead of the default 0.5. τ is fitted on the clean benign half of the evaluation split to a 5% false-positive budget, and it is the *smallest* threshold that meets that budget, that is, the least conservative setting the budget allows. Two figures travel with every headline number: the clean false-positive rate at τ, and the clean true-positive rate it costs. Without the second, a drop in ASR cannot be told apart from a filter that has simply stopped flagging mail.

The direction of the search matters and is easy to get backwards. A larger τ always has a lower false-positive rate, so maximising it under an upper bound is trivially satisfied by "above every clean score" — a filter that flags nothing. That is the failure mode the code now prevents: maximising τ and counting a flip whenever an edited text falls below τ, without asking whether the original was above it, reported a 100% ASR for the defence. Both rules are enforced in code: τ is the minimum feasible value, and a sample counts as flipped only if the *same* rule classified the *original* text as malicious.

Reading the outcome. Three outcomes are possible and all three are informative: a defence that removes the flips it targets (D1 against the character attack), a defence that removes none (D1 against a word attack it cannot see), and a defence that trades a small amount of clean precision for a large reduction in evasions (D2). What we do not do is report a defence at a different operating point from the baseline and call the difference robustness.

Under the char attack, normalisation moves the aggregate ASR from 1.0% to 0.0%. Under the word attack, normalisation moves the aggregate ASR from 2.5% to 2.0%. Under the saliency attack, normalisation moves the aggregate ASR from 7.5% to 6.9%. The threshold is not free: at the 5% clean false-positive budget its tightest operating point (SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct, SMS smishing) keeps clean recall at 23.0%, down from 100.0% at the default threshold. 1 of 6 model–task cells cannot meet the budget at all: holding their false positives down requires a threshold so high that it flags no message at all.

Table 9 is read column by column, because its baseline column uses the probability channel the threshold needs and the attack tables do not; the next section says what that costs the comparison.

9 DISCUSSION AND LIMITATIONS

9.1 Why a low evasion rate is a result, not a failed attack

Some readers might view an attack success rate of 0.0–5.1% as a failed attack. In our setting, the opposite reading is more accurate. The attack spends its full edit budget. It changes 13.3–13.6% of characters and 6.2–9.2% of words. It runs up to three attempts per sample. In total, it flips 40 decisions. What the attack does not do is guided search. It draws edits at random instead of selecting the most damaging ones.

Section 6 shows why search matters. We test synonym replacements under the same 15% word budget. When substitutions are ordered by measured saliency (their observed impact on the model's decision), the flip rate is 4.6%. When substitutions are chosen at random, the flip rate is only 2.7%. In paired tests, saliency flips 33 messages that random edits miss, while random edits flip only 7 that saliency misses. Thus, we should not claim these models are robust. Instead, under random bounded edits they rarely flip; under a guided search with the same budget, they flip about twice as often.

Table 8: Cross-model transfer on the applied subset: every perturbation the source produced is replayed on the target, and the denominator is the TARGET's own caught originals, because a perturbation cannot transfer on a message the target never flagged. No diagonal is tabulated: replaying a model's own perturbations reproduces its attack run and would only reprint Table 3. That replay was run as a faithfulness check and its diagonal appears in the prose below, not as a result. Cells with fewer than ten caught originals would be marked †; none in this table needed it.

Mode	Task	Source	Target	Caught	Flips	ASR	95% CI
char	SMS smishing	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	163	0	0.0%	0.0–2.3
		Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	160	0	0.0%	0.0–2.3
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	163	1	0.6%	0.1–3.4
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	179	0	0.0%	0.0–2.1
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	160	1	0.6%	0.1–3.5
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	179	0	0.0%	0.0–2.1
char	Phishing email	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	119	0	0.0%	0.0–3.1
		Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	120	0	0.0%	0.0–3.1
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	119	4	3.4%	1.3–8.3
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	189	0	0.0%	0.0–2.0
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	120	2	1.7%	0.5–5.9
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	189	1	0.5%	0.1–2.9
word	SMS smishing	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	161	1	0.6%	0.1–3.4
		Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	158	1	0.6%	0.1–3.5
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	162	3	1.8%	0.6–5.3
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	178	0	0.0%	0.0–2.1
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	160	1	0.6%	0.1–3.5
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	178	4	2.2%	0.9–5.6
word	Phishing email	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	117	0	0.0%	0.0–3.2
		Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	118	0	0.0%	0.0–3.1
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	119	4	3.4%	1.3–8.3
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	188	0	0.0%	0.0–2.0
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	120	3	2.5%	0.9–7.1
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	188	1	0.5%	0.1–2.9
saliency	SMS smishing	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	163	1	0.6%	0.1–3.4
		Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	160	0	0.0%	0.0–2.3
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	154	2	1.3%	0.4–4.6
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	163	1	0.6%	0.1–3.4
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	160	0	0.0%	0.0–2.3
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	179	4	2.2%	0.9–5.6
saliency	Phishing email	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	119	1	0.8%	0.1–4.6
		Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	120	0	0.0%	0.0–3.1
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	113	4	3.5%	1.4–8.8
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	167	1	0.6%	0.1–3.3
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	120	5	4.2%	1.8–9.4
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	189	5	2.6%	1.1–6.0

9.2 Word edits cost fewer changes and flip more decisions

Word-level changes flip more decisions than character-level noise (28 versus 12 flips). At the same time, word edits modify fewer units (6.2–9.2% of words versus 13.3–13.6% of characters). The paired analysis in Section 5.7 confirms this pattern. Word edits outperform character edits in five of six cells, and the pooled difference is significant (26 versus 10, $p = 0.011$). The text similarity values explain this outcome. Word edits preserve 92–95% of original words. Character edits leave only 30.3–32.8% word overlap. A homoglyph (a character that looks like another) alters the token representation even when human readers see no change.

9.3 Vulnerability is concentrated in specific words

The saliency results clarify how random attacks behave. If an evasion succeeds only when striking specific decisive words, a random draw from a small dictionary rarely hits them. That explains the low 2.7% baseline flip rate.

The saliency attack confirms this behaviour. Most evasions require only two or three targeted word substitutions. However, the saliency attack edits more words on average (9.3% versus 7.6%, as shown in Table 4). Normalised by edit rate, its advantage is roughly 1.4 times rather than 1.7 times. Thus, vulnerability is concentrated

Table 9: Training-free defences, measured on the same stored perturbations. *None* is the undefended ASR, *norm* applies input normalisation only, *thr* replaces the default decision threshold with one fitted on clean benign mail to a 5% false-positive budget. Rows are pooled over the three models; *n* is the number of originals the undefended rule itself flagged, and *n/a* means a defence flagged none of them, so there was nothing left to flip. † marks a row containing a model-task pair whose false-positive budget could not be met: its threshold is a rejection rule, not a defence, and the number is there to be ignored.

Mode	Task	None	Norm.	Thr.	*n*
char	SMS smishing	0.6%	0.0%	2.3%†	515
char	Phishing email	1.4%	0.0%	7.7%	486
word	SMS smishing	2.1%	2.1%	4.7%†	512
word	Phishing email	2.9%	1.9%	5.4%	483
saliency	SMS smishing	6.6%	6.6%	19.9%†	515
saliency	Phishing email	8.4%	7.3%	18.9%	486

in specific tokens. This finding is useful for defenders because targeted words can be filtered. It also warns against taking random perturbation rates as proof of general robustness.

This effect varies across models. Phi-3.5-mini shows the largest increase: its ASR roughly doubles under the saliency attack (11.7% and 7.4% versus 5.1% and 3.7% under random word edits), although its probability channel saturates at 0.9999 or above on 800 of its 845 stored rows, so the increase cannot be read as a margin effect. Qwen2.5-3B is more accurate and does not flip more often under saliency (2.4% and 0.6% versus 2.6% and 3.2%). Its remaining errors cannot be reached by this candidate vocabulary.

9.4 Two channels of one model are not one measurement

The saliency attack requires continuous scores, so it optimises the predicted probability $P(\text{malicious})$ over two answer tokens. The rest of this paper evaluates the generated text decision. We rechecked every stored saliency sample with text generation. The two channels agree on 941 of 1,001 rows. The disagreements are systematic. For Phi-3.5-mini, both channels agree on all rows. For Qwen2.5-3B, the probability channel claims 45 flips that generation does not confirm. For SmolLM2-1.7B, generation claims 15 flips that the probability channel misses.

This gap occurs because a two-token probability channel does not match free-form decoding. When answer words split into subtokens, probability ratios can point one way while greedy decoding points the other. We report final text decisions throughout the paper. We view the divergence as a limitation of probability probing in small language models.

9.5 The transfer we observe is low

We replayed every stored perturbation (character, word, and saliency) against every other model. Very few perturbations transferred. On the applied subset, only 51 of 5,514 caught messages (0.9%) flipped off the diagonal. Specifically, 9 flips came from 1,860 character edits, 18 from 1,847 word edits, and 24 from 1,807 saliency edits. Guided edits transferred slightly better than random edits. However, confidence intervals overlap, indicating a broad trend rather than a sharp separation. In the classic flipped-source matrix, only 5 of 31 cells are non-zero; 27 of the 31 hold fewer than ten caught originals; and every non-zero cell there carries one or two flips.

A 0.9% rate indicates low observed transfer, not total immunity. Fifty-one messages did cross model boundaries. Either these perturbations are model-specific, or they are too weak to cross distant decision boundaries. In either case, robustness evaluations on one model do not guarantee safety on another.

9.6 Defences: character cleaning succeeds while re-thresholding fails

Character normalisation cleans visually confusable characters. It removes every character-level flip (1.0% to 0.0% pooled). It leaves word and saliency attacks largely unaffected (2.5% to 2.0%, and 7.5% to 6.9%). This confirms our hypothesis: distinct perturbation types fail for distinct reasons.

Re-thresholding yields mixed results. We adjust the threshold τ to enforce a 5% clean false-positive budget. This reduces flips on well-calibrated models. However, on SmolLM2-1.7B (where clean scores cluster near 1.0), it increases evasions: 0.0% to 29.0% on email and 0.0% to 13.3% on SMS. There the fitted threshold sits inside the cluster of clean scores, so a small edit is enough to push a message below the cutoff. It also lowers clean recall on SmolLM2-1.7B (100% to 34.5% and 23.0%). For one task cell, the budget cannot be met without a threshold that flags nothing at all.

9.7 Limitations

Search strength. Random perturbations are weak adversaries. The saliency attack uses greedy first-order search over a fixed candidate set. It is not a full implementation of PWWS or TextFooler, nor is it a white-box gradient attack. Reported ASR values are lower bounds on attacker capabilities.

Transfer coverage. The transfer matrix covers all three attacks. Faithfulness is verified by self-replay: diagonal cells match the original attack logs exactly. These tests demonstrate harness consistency on a single GPU environment rather than universal cross-platform reproducibility.

Unmatched vocabulary in primary tables. The saliency attack uses a broader vocabulary than the random word attack. The ablation in Section 6.1 isolates vocabulary, ordering and information effects

across five arms. The reported contrasts in Table 7 hold candidate sets and query caps constant.

Defence operating point. The defence probe evaluates a 5% false-positive budget using probability scores. Because thresholding requires numeric scores, its baseline column is not directly comparable to text verdict tables.

Saliency denominator. Its 1,001 messages against 2,079 for the random attacks follow from the 52 exclusions of Section 3: 43 saliency originals that the probability channel read as benign (all on Qwen2.5-3B) and nine word-attack no-op edits.

Similarity metric. We report word-level Jaccard similarity without neural sentence embeddings. For character edits, Jaccard similarity is an imperfect proxy, and actual edit rate is the cleaner measure.

Uncertainty scope. Confidence intervals represent sample variation over messages, not seed variability across runs.

Sample design. Attacks target the correctly classified subset of an 800-row evaluation split. This provides an accurate conditional denominator but does not represent out-of-distribution generalisation.

Model coverage. We evaluate three open models. Llama-3.2-3B-Instruct was omitted due to access restrictions.

Task construct. SMS smishing is evaluated on the UCI SMS Spam dataset, where spam includes broader commercial promotions. Phishing email data comes from public benchmark collections.

Missing experiments. Two designed attacks were not run; Section 9.8 says what each of them would test.

9.8 Future Work

Four measurements would move this line of work forward. None of them is claimed above, and each of them is a place where the current numbers stop.

A sentence-level paraphrase attacker. Every edit measured here is local: a character, a word, a synonym. An attacker who rewrites whole sentences — keeping the same request and the same lure — is a different kind of threat, and the shared 15% edit budget does not describe it, because a paraphrase can change most of the message while leaving the meaning intact. Two pieces would be needed before such an attack could sit in the same table as the ones above: a reliable meaning check, so that a rewrite is counted only when a reader would treat it as the same request; and a cost model, because the rewriter is itself a model call and the query accounting of Section 6 would have to include it. The open question is whether the attack success that our bounded search leaves on the table is reachable this way. Nothing measured here answers that.

A defence-aware attacker. The two defences of Section 8 were measured against perturbations built without any knowledge of them. That is the honest way to measure a defence once, and the wrong way to conclude that it holds. An attacker who can see the character normaliser and the threshold spends the same budget differently: a substitution outside the normaliser's mapping table passes through unchanged, and a threshold is a number to be pushed under. Repeating the character and word attacks with the defence in the loop — the normaliser applied before every query, the threshold known to the search — is the experiment that would say whether the residual flip rate we report is a floor or a first measurement. Until it runs, the defence results should be read as a property of the perturbation set, not of the defence.

The models we could not run. Llama-3.2-3B-Instruct was omitted because it is gated, and the three models we do report sit in one size band. We therefore cannot say whether fragility grows or shrinks with model size, and we do not: the discussion of Section 9 compares models of similar capacity. Attacking a 1B, a 3B and an 8B model of the same family on the same messages would answer a simple question that a deployment actually asks — is the near-constant decision rule of the strongest model here a property of that model, or of its size? The experiment is the only way to find out.

Run-to-run variability. Our intervals cover variation across messages, not across runs. Sampling, prompt order and batching all move the generated verdict at the margin, and a flip count of a few dozen messages is exactly the scale at which that noise matters. Repeating one attack under several seeds, and reporting the spread next to the interval, would tell a reader how much of a two-point gap between two rows is real. It would also turn the single-run numbers in this paper into a distribution, which is what the paired tests already assume.

None of these changes a number reported above. Each of them changes what those numbers would be allowed to mean.

10 ETHICS AND ARTEFACT AVAILABILITY

Dual use. The perturbations studied here are text edits that any sender can apply by hand; no exploit, payload or delivery mechanism is introduced. Two of the three adversaries are random draws, but the third is not, and we describe it as it is rather than as a stronger random draw: the saliency attack *does* select the substitution to apply, per message, using measured model behaviour, and the ablation of Section 6.1 adds a TextFooler-style importance ranking on the same candidate set. That is a targeted search. It is also not a new capability: PWWS and TextFooler are published, TextAttack implements both, and this implementation is weaker than either — a greedy first-order search over a hand-built lexicon plus WordNet, with a 24-call cap, a 15% word budget and a lexical paraphrase constraint, on open checkpoints. No attack here is tuned against a deployed classifier, no victim system is probed, and nothing released lowers the cost of an attack below what those toolkits already provide. We report that small triage models resist the random adversaries and that the targeted one roughly doubles the flip rate, which is the defensive direction of the finding: both numbers tell an operator that a random-draw ASR is not a robustness guarantee. Withholding the measurement would leave operators believing a false-positive prone detector is robust.

Data. Both corpora are public and contain no live credentials or personally identifiable information beyond what their publishers already released. No human subjects were involved; no production system was probed.

Reporting honesty. Seven measurement defects were found and fixed in our own pipeline before the numbers in this paper were produced:

- per-operation edit budgets that reached 22% while the paper claimed 15%;
- estimated rather than measured edit counts;
- a similarity metric labelled BERTScore that was word Jaccard;
- an attack set drawn from messages the model had never caught;
- a saliency score that is a constant at $\alpha = 0.5$ unless it is normalised, which silently reduced the greedy search to applying substitutions left to right;
- an answer-token lookup that compared the same whitespace token for both answers on one tokenizer, making the verdict probability exactly 0.5 for every message;
- a defence threshold chosen by maximising the cutoff rather than minimising it, which flagged nothing and, together with unconditional flip counting, reported a 100% attack success rate for the defence.

The last three were caught by unit tests that check the mechanism rather than the headline number — the runs they produced looked entirely plausible. Each of these defects inflated an apparent effect, and none of them would have been visible to a reader of the results alone. The per-sample records shipped with the artefact are the ones the tables are rebuilt from, so a reader can recompute every number in this paper without a GPU.

Availability. Code, frozen splits and per-sample results are at https://github.com/daud-glitch/SilentEvasion. The artefact contains the frozen splits with fingerprints, the prompt, the perturbation code for all three attacks, the five ablation arms of Section 6.1, the defence probe, the per-sample attack records (including every perturbed text), both channels for the saliency rows, the transfer replays, the threshold fits, the table-generation script and the script that produces every table in this paper from those records. A single command recomputes the tables and fails if a number in the text no longer matches the records; a second command re-runs the study end to end on a free-tier GPU in about two hours (the random-attack run of Section 4 is 37.1 minutes of that; the saliency, ablation, transfer and defence passes are the rest). The split fingerprints are published so that a reader can prove their rebuild is the split these numbers came from, and the calibration slice that tunes α and the meaning threshold is disjoint from both the evaluation and the attack slice, asserted at build time.

11 CONCLUSION

We measured what a bounded, black-box text perturbation buys an attacker against three small language models. These models work zero-shot for security triage. Under a shared 15% edit budget, random character-level perturbation flips 0.0–5.0% of the messages a model had already caught. Random word-level perturbation flips 1.0–5.1% while changing about half as many units. Ordering the same word edit by measured saliency roughly doubles that: 4.6% against 2.7%, 33 message-specific flips against 7 when both are paired on the messages they share.

Three things follow. First, a robustness number is a property of the search as much as of the model. Inside the same 15% word budget, choosing substitutions rather than drawing them nearly doubles the flip rate (2.7% to 4.6%). That comparison is not on the same messages, nor from the same candidate vocabulary. Once we account for the higher budget actually spent, the factor is 1.4, not 1.7. The search, the candidates, and the denominator must all be named in the claim. Second, at this budget the binding constraint on a small triage model is what it catches before any attack. What orders the flip rate is neither accuracy nor the measured margin: the model that flips most is neither the least accurate nor the closest to its threshold, and its probability channel saturates, so the margin cannot be read on it at all. The model that catches almost everything is immovable because its decision rule is nearly constant. Detection quality, not adversarial robustness, is where deployment effort pays first. Third, cheap defences split cleanly. Normalising visually confusable characters removes every character-level flip and only a small part of the word-level ones (7.5% to 6.9%). Rethresholding to hold a false-positive budget can create evasions on a model whose scores are least calibrated.

The measurement lesson runs through all of it. The transfer we observed was low (0.9% of caught messages off the diagonal). Per-model numbers are worth measuring separately. The probability channel and the generated verdict agreed on 941 of 1,001 rows. They diverged systematically on two of three models. A single channel is not a measurement until it is checked against the other. Every result in this paper reports its denominator and its interval, and Section 10 lists the bugs we fixed in our own pipeline. Each bug silently inflated the attack success rate in the direction that makes a paper look interesting.

The matched-vocabulary, matched-budget ablation of Section 6.1 is the one experiment here that attributes rather than describes. With the candidate set, the probe phase, and the call budget held fixed, it reports what ordering is worth on its own. What it cannot do is turn five contrasts on roughly a thousand paired messages into a ranking of attacks. Section 9.8 names the two attacks that would test what remains; neither is reported here.

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